



Scale Choices — what to play over what

UNDERCOVER ZEST

[undercoverzest.app](#) — free songwriting tools

The working answers, not the theory lecture. Degrees relative to each chord's own root.

BLUES (KEY OF A USED IN EXAMPLES)

OVER

Whole blues, down-home

I7 chord (A7)

IV7 / V7 (D7, E7)

Uptown / jazz-blues

Minor blues

PLAY

A minor pentatonic + b5

A major pentatonic lean

A minor pentatonic lean

chord tones: land each 3rd

A natural minor / dorian

NOTES

one scale over everything; band makes the tension

sweetness at home; mix with minor pent freely

grit when you leave home

C# over A7, F# over D7, G# over E7

dorian (raised 6) over the iv chord sounds modern

JAZZ — CHORD-BY-CHORD (THE 90% ANSWERS)

OVER

maj7 (Cmaj7)

m7 (Dm7)

7 (G7)

m7b5 (Dm7b5)

dim7

7alt (G7alt)

PLAY

major scale (ionian)

dorian

mixolydian

locrian

whole-half diminished

altered scale

NOTES

or lydian (#4) when it is the IV chord

minor with a raised 6 — the default jazz minor

major with a b7; add the b9/#9 colours later

or locrian natural-2 for a friendlier sound

symmetrical; every minor 3rd transposition works

melodic minor a half-step up (Ab mel. minor over G7)

THE HONEST SHORTCUTS

- Guide tones beat scales: the 3rd and 7th of each chord, connected by step, outline everything.
- Over a whole ii-V-I, the I chord's major scale already contains all three chords' notes.
- Blues scale over jazz blues always works at a jam. Taste comes later.
- When lost: play the melody. Nobody ever complained.